



Panache Black Current

Compact and Affordable

With its attractive size, the Black Current might draw the attention of those who want an HTPC. The Panache Black Current comes without a monitor, so basically you will be getting the cabinet and everything inside it – nothing else.

The motherboard is a mini-ITX form factor and does not have many upgrade options due to its form factor. It comes

with two DIMM slots, two SATA ports and just a single PCIe x1 expansion slot. There is no chance of installing a discreet graphics solution here. The cabinet also is quite tightly packed with one optical drive slot which is already in use. The hard drive is mounted vertically on the side. There are two SATA connectors, one being used by the hard drive and the other by the optical drive, so expansion is a problem. The CPU heat-sink and fan are not the regular size, but instead there is a low profile heat-sink to compensate for the lack of space within the cabinet. The model we received comes with a Core 2 Duo E7400, a pretty up-to-date configuration which will easily handle any quality high-definition content.

There are some things lacking in the Panache Black Current – firstly there is no HDMI port, which means that even though this could make a good HTPC, it lacks the most essential connectiv-

ity option. Next is the lack of an expansion slot for a graphics card for those of you who would want to play some games on their HTPC. For a person who does not want to go through building an HTPC this would be ideal, but for a gamer who wants to play on a 42 inch LCD, this PC is lacking in the (3D) graphics department.

Specifications:

Processor: Intel Core 2 Duo E7400 @ 2.8 GHz,
Cache: 3 MB, FSB: 1066 MHz, Chipset: Nvidia 610i, Memory: 2 GB DDR2 800 MHz, Hard Disk Drive: WD 320 GB Caviar Blue

Ratings

Features: 7
Performance: 7
Build quality: 7
Value for money: 8.5
Overall: 7.5

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Price: Rs. 16,500



ASUS Rampage II Gene

Honey I Shrunk My Rampage

Even though this is an mATX board, it has all the features of a full-sized ATX board. The GENE also supports either 2-way SLI or CrossFire as it has two PCIe x16 slots. These slots are separated by a single PCIe x1 slot. A very noticeable feature in that the DIMM slots hold the memory in place by a single clamp instead of the traditional clamp on both ends of the slot. This makes for a very intelligent design for when you need to remove a memory stick, you do not need to remove the graphics card that is usually present and blocks the removal of the RAM stick. The overall layout is good, the heatpipes are sturdy, the SATA connectors are facing outwards so that the wires aren't cramped for space.

ASUS has also provided an LCD poster along with this motherboard. When there is an error or problem, the board detects this and displays the errors during POST. Very useful for quick diagnostics when problems occur.

The first option that you see in the BIOS is the Extreme Tweaker which has many controls that can be used to overclock your processor, memory, etc. There are LED indica-

tors on the motherboard itself that change colour to warn you against overvolting. This motherboard also lets you overclock on the fly via Tweakit.

We tested this motherboard with the Intel Core i7 965, 3 GB of Kingston Hyper X memory running at 1,333 MHz and an ASUS ENGTX285 TOP. The GENE performed equally well compared to the other X58 boards we have reviewed. Game benchmarks also gave some great scores from games such as Doom 3 and Prey. A 4 GB file transfer test took a total of 69 seconds while video encoding a 100 MB file through the DivX converter took 79.3 seconds.

Priced at Rs. 16,750, this board is best suited for gamers who want to save space or attend many LAN parties as the small size will be a bonus.

Specifications:

CPU Socket: LGA 1366, Chipset: Intel X58 / ICH10R, Audio: SupremeFX X-Fi onboard 8 - Channel High Definition Audio CODEC



Ratings

Features: 8
Performance: 8
Build quality: 8
Value for money: 7
Overall: 7.5

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